

He's like, 'let's go, let's do it.' He's a fantastic motivator." To think that in 2006 when Houghton took over, Bhutia had virtually quit playing for India. Differences with Naeemuddin, who is an old-style disciplinarian, were driving Bhutia away from India colours. "I wasn't learning anything, I wasn't enjoying it." A meeting with Houghton in Kolkata changed his mind and captain and coach have shepherded the Indian team to their best results in decades.

They are results Bhutia hopes will stop all the lazy generalisations around football and India. That FIFA ranking that everyone moans about is mostly related to the number of international friendlies India plays—10-12 is the minimum and the Nehru Cup included, India this year have played just five.

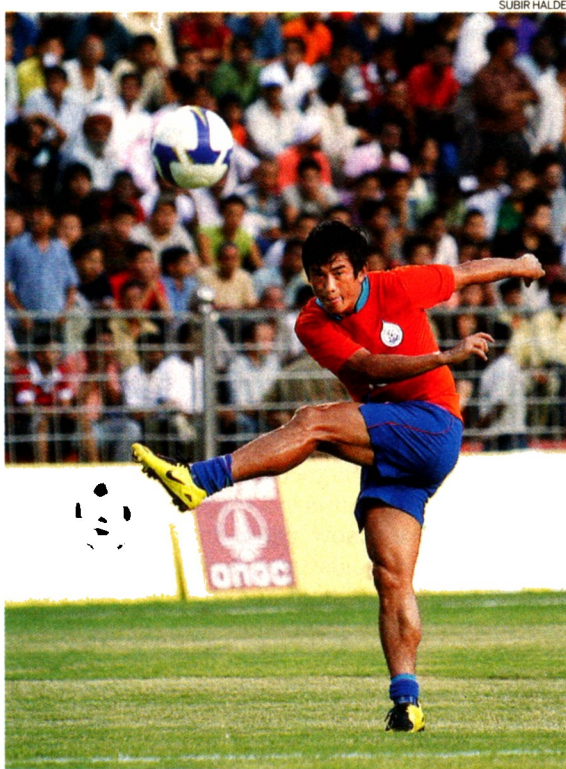
Then the other thing: the gap between Indian and overseas footballers, he says, is neither physical or technical skill but mental. Stints with English club Bury and Malaysian side Perak helped, he said, mentally, more than anything. "If you're not confident, don't go on the field in a good frame of mind, you don't play the way you *really* can."

Even there, Bhutia has re-drawn the map for Indian footballers. They say he 'arrived' in the semis of the 1993 Durand Cup. More precisely in the 10th minute of extra time. Six-foot bsr defenders watched as a 5ft-8 inch, seventeen-year-old baby-face flung himself into a bicycle kick and fired the winner for East Bengal. Commentator-writer Novy Kapadia remembers the instant: "For a second, there was silence in the crowd, like they couldn't believe what they had seen. They never thought an Indian could do that. Then they erupted."

Bhutia's gifts, the experts say, are as internal as external. Bhowmick says, "I have seen players technically much better than him, but where he

scores is willpower." Naeemuddin would have liked him to do more while Sukumar Samajpati says Bhutia's opportunism was his greatest strength. "He can turn impossible situations into goals. His fitness allows him to score from impossible angles."

Bhutia's former colleague I.M. Vijayan was rated by many as superior to Bhutia in terms of skill but will have none of it. He says Bhutia is the best Indian football has seen in the last 25



BHUTIA IS INDIAN FOOTBALL'S ONLY SUPERSTAR, A GREAT TEAM MAN AND THE BEST EXAMPLE TO OTHERS

years. "We are differently abled. I was good in finishing or scoring while Bhutia tops in every department of the game. He can single-handedly transform a team's total performance." The spindly Keralite and the sturdy Sikkimese, old comrades on the frontline, still speak every week.

Ask Houghton and he says simply, "If I had to leave India and go back to Europe, I would take him with me. At this stage of his career."

The older Bhutia gets, the more it seems he wants to do. He is almost evangelical about the Football Players

Association of India (FPAI) set up in 2006. Already, the FPAI has helped former player Ashok Chatterjee who was suffering from cancer and played a charity match for the family of Sanjib Dutta, a railways' player who had died on the field during the Santosh Trophy. They also offer players financial advice, legal help in contractual matters, spoken-English classes, organise coaching clinics and corporate events and work with football-centric NGOs.

Bhutia is the FPAI president and says stories about Olympians and internationals down on hard times strike deep. "I'm not saying footballers won't struggle for things but at least now, I don't want guys who played for the national team to be struggling for a meal."

The FPAI website was launched during the Nehru Cup and Bhutia was front and centre of all publicity around the event. His essential media-savviness is not so much image-manipulation as winning space for football. He can handle the spotlight with ease, be it dancing on a TV show or refusing to carry the Beijing Olympics torch over the Tibet issue. He's a Buddhist but not religious. "I won't wait for an hour in a line for a blessing. I'm a realist." The romantic in him probably plays football for India.

It is the day before the Nehru Cup final and a hotel bell boy approaches him. He's

not really a boy, more a moustachioed, rotund footsoldier in a Ranjikanth army. The man wishes Bhutia luck and says, "*Aadha ghanta puja-path karta hoon. Nehru Cup apna hai.* (I pray for half an hour every day. The Nehru Cup is ours)."

They shake hands for a moment and it is more than formal gesture. It is almost a sign of recognition. As if they, Indian football star and Indian football fan, instinctively know each other. Actually they do. They share, after all, a common heartbeat.

with M.G. Radhakrishnan and Elora Sen